

El Niño economic toll will be shaped by government responses

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El Niño economic toll will be shaped by government responses

A “super” El Niño is expected to shave up to \$1 trillion from global output, though export controls could amplify the shock; if Hormuz and Black Sea disruptions persist, benchmark food commodity prices could rise 10%-18% above February 2026 levels.

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A confirmed “super” El Niño will peak between November and February, could cost the global economy up to \$1 trillion, and will hit Andean countries, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Indonesia, and the Philippines the hardest.

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Persistent disruptions in Hormuz and the Black Sea would compound El Niño’s effects, likely pushing benchmark food commodity prices 10%-18% above February 2026 levels and raising retail prices by 1%-2.5% in advanced economies and by 3%-6% in vulnerable, import-dependent markets.

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Governments in South Asia and Africa are expanding grain reserves and activating drought protocols to cushion El Niño’s impact, but hard-hit countries may still adopt protectionist policies such as export controls that could worsen global effects.

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